Germanic encounter with Eastern Europeans began as early as the times of the Franks, continuing throughout the centuries of the Holy Roman Empire of the German Nation and the Austrian Habsburg Empire right up to the Nazi period. It was German speakers who pushed the Slavs towards the east and the south, colonising the more sparsely populated areas and bringing with them also urban culture, advanced agricultural techniques and industry. This colonisation was organised but it did not yet have the characteristics of planned Germanisation. Whether the peasants were Slav or German did not make much difference to the feudal lords, most of whom (though not all) were German-speaking. Still, the net effect was that the Germanic-Slavic ethnic border was pushed further to the east and to the south. So, for example, in Carinthia, the southern province of Austria, which in the early Middle Ages was the political centre of the early Slovenians, there is now only a minority Slovenian community.

Gradually, this silent change of the ethnic structure began to have political implications, as Germanic nobility took lands away from indigenous landlords, usually of local ethnic origin. In the nineteenth century, in the era of revolutions and the births of nation states, this became a serious issue. The relatively peaceful coexistence of Slavs and Germans began to collapse, destroying the Central European idyll. Slavic nations within the Austrian Empire began to fight for their place in the sun. Usually the battle took the peaceful form of vigorous political and civil campaigns for the public use of the local Slavic language and enforcement of already existing legislation in favour of equality. There was pressure to change the signage on public offices, pubs and shops. There were colourful political confrontations on urban and provincial councils, and there was competition between rival societies and social clubs, sport organisations, etc. However, clashes between protesters and police occurred and there were even casualties. The fight was mostly fought in the cities, because it was there that most German speakers resided. Sometimes they even formed a majority of the urban population, surrounded by an almost exclusively Slavic countryside.

The term ‘Central Europe’ (sometimes the German name *Mitteleuropa* is used) came into existence during the process of German nation-building. It was a Prussian invention, which was then taken over by the Habsburgs and later also by the Visegrad countries (Poland, the Czech Republic, Slovakia